

01

Buddhist Foundation, Middle Way and School Map

Context + Exact Core

Buddhist schools share dependent origination and the cessation of suffering while differing over the status of external objects, consciousness, dharmas and emptiness.

Mechanism / Argument

Ignorance conditions craving and suffering, while insight into conditioned arising interrupts that sequence and makes cessation possible.

Consequence / Contrast

A common practical path can support realist, representationalist, consciousness-only and emptiness-based philosophical interpretations.

UPSC Trap / Answer Use

Do not treat Buddhism as one uniform metaphysics or confuse no permanent self with denial of causal and moral continuity.

Answer Line: The unity of Buddhist philosophy lies in its causal and soteriological method; its diversity lies in competing accounts of what, if anything, is ultimately real.

02

Dependent Origination and the Four Noble Truths

Context + Exact Core

□ The classical chain of dependent origination is expressed through the dvādaśa-nidāna sequence avidyā — ignorance saṃskāra — formations/dispositions vijñāna — consciousness nāma-rūpa — name-and-form saḍāyatana — six sense-bases sparśa — contact vedanā — feeling tṛṣṇā — craving upādāna — clinging/grasping bhava — becoming/existence jāti — birth jarā-maraṇa — old age and death □ In visual Buddhist pedagogy, this sequence is often represented through the bhava-cakra (wheel of becoming), showing how ignorance and craving keep cyclic existence in motion.

Mechanism / Argument

□ Buddhism states the problem first: dukkha. □ It then identifies a causal structure: dukkha has an origin. □ Because the origin is conditioned, it can cease. □ Therefore a path is possible. □□ So dependent origination is the philosophical grammar of the Four Noble Truths.

Consequence / Contrast

Its primary concern is soteriological: to show that suffering is conditioned and therefore stoppable. □□ UPSC answers should stress that dependent origination is not a failed search for a first cause; it is a diagnosis of dependent becoming.

UPSC Trap / Answer Use

□ Pratītyasamutpāda means dependent origination: whatever arises, arises depending on causes and conditions; whatever ceases, ceases when those conditions cease. □ The standard formula, in substance, is: "imaṣmiṃ sati idam hoti; imaṣṣ' uppādā idam uppajjati; imaṣmiṃ asaṭi idam na hoti; imassa nirodha idam nirujjhati" — this being, that becomes; from the arising of this, that arises; this not being, that is not; from the cessation of this, that ceases. □ It is not merely a cosmological thesis.

Answer Line: pratītyasamutpāda (dependent origination) is the principle that phenomena arise and cease in dependence on conditions, rejecting both eternalism and causeless annihilationism.

03

Momentariness, Causal Efficiency and Continuity

Context + Exact Core

□ Arthakriyākāritva (causal efficacy / capacity to perform a function) is the Buddhist pramāṇa-school criterion of the real: sat = arthakriyā-samartha — the real is what is capable of producing an effect. □ Kṣaṇikavāda follows because whatever is causally effective must be moment-specific; a wholly permanent entity cannot explain why an effect appears now rather than always. □□ This is the bridge between Buddhist epistemology and ontology: the same test that ranks svalakṣaṇa (unique particular) as ultimately real also grounds the thesis yat sat tat kṣaṇikam — whatever is real is momentary.

Mechanism / Argument

□ The Buddhist reply is that if the permanent thing remains wholly unchanged, then the decisive factor lies elsewhere; its own efficacy is redundant. □ Recognition is explained through sādṛśya (similarity) within a causal stream, not strict numerical identity. □ Memory and desert are explained through santāna / santati (causal continuum), with ālaya-vijñāna and bīja (seeds) supplying the Yogācāra version of the continuity device. □□ The Nyāya rejoinder retains force: a mere series seems unable to own memories or deserts unless something owns the series.

Consequence / Contrast

□ Santāna: memory belongs to the same causal stream, not to a permanent self. □ Pratisandhāna: reconnection/relinking explains continuity across moments and lives. □ Ālaya-vijñāna in Yogācāra: a store-consciousness carries latent impressions (bīja, seeds), explaining the preservation of karmic and mnemonic potential.

UPSC Trap / Answer Use

□ Arthakriyākāritva (causal efficacy / capacity to perform a function) is the Buddhist pramāṇa-school criterion of the real: sat = arthakriyā-samartha — the real is what is capable of producing an effect. □ Kṣaṇikavāda follows because whatever is causally effective must be moment-specific; a wholly permanent entity cannot explain why an effect appears now rather than always. □□ This is the bridge between Buddhist epistemology and ontology: the same test that ranks svalakṣaṇa (unique particular) as ultimately real also grounds the thesis yat sat tat kṣaṇikam — whatever is real is momentary.

Answer Line: Kṣaṇikavāda (doctrine of momentariness) holds that whatever is causally efficient exists only momentarily, because a permanent entity could neither change its causal power nor produce genuinely successive effects.

04

No-Self, the Five Skandhas and Nirvāṇa

Context + Exact Core

□ The person is analysed into five skandhas rūpa — form/material body vedanā — feeling/sensation saṃjñā — perception/recognition saṃskāra — dispositions/formations vijñāna — consciousness □□ The philosophical force of the doctrine lies in exhaustive analysis: if what we call self reduces to these aggregates and no extra owner is found, the self is a conceptual imputation, not an independently real substance.

Mechanism / Argument

□ The question "who attains?" assumes the very self Buddhism rejects. □ Nirvāṇa is not an entity possessed by a soul. □ It is the cessation of craving, ignorance and the suffering-series grounded in them. □□ So consonance exists: no-self removes the false claimant to liberation; momentariness explains why the chain can in fact cease.

Consequence / Contrast

□ The person is analysed into five skandhas rūpa — form/material body vedanā — feeling/sensation saṃjñā — perception/recognition saṃskāra — dispositions/formations vijñāna — consciousness □□ The philosophical force of the doctrine lies in exhaustive analysis: if what we call self reduces to these aggregates and no extra owner is found, the self is a conceptual imputation, not an independently real substance.

UPSC Trap / Answer Use

□ The classic chariot analogy argues that "chariot" is merely a name for the arrangement of axle, wheels, yoke and other parts. □ Likewise, "person" is a conventional designation for the aggregate of skandhas. □□ The point is not that the person is uselessly unreal.

Answer Line: Nairātmyavāda (no-self doctrine) denies an eternal ātman (self) and explains the person as a dependently ordered continuum of five skandhas (aggregates), preserving conventional identity without a permanent substance.

05

Vaiśiṣṭika and Sautrāntika Realisms

Context + Exact Core

□ Usually associated with Sarvāstivāda realism. □ Holds bāhya-pratyakṣa-vāda: external objects are directly perceived. □ Affirms sarvam asti in the technical sense that dharmas of past, present and future have some mode of existence.

Mechanism / Argument

□ Holds bāhyānumeya-vāda: external objects exist, but are known only inferentially through mental representations. □ Rejects the Sarvāstivāda thesis that past and future dharmas exist in the same sense as present ones. □ Strongly privileges the present moment.

Consequence / Contrast

□□ Vaiśiṣṭika preserves Buddhist anti-self doctrine while still maintaining a robust realism about dharmas. □□ It is therefore a useful contrast both to Yogācāra idealism and to Mādhyamika anti-essentialism.

UPSC Trap / Answer Use

Do not miss this limiting distinction: □ Usually associated with Sarvāstivāda realism. □ Holds bāhya-pratyakṣa-vāda.

Answer Line: The four-school debate moves from Vaiśiṣṭika (Abhidharma realist school) and Sautrāntika (Sūtra-based representationalist school) to Yogācāra (yoga-practice consciousness-centred school) and Mādhyamika (Middle Way emptiness school), progressively questioning what can count as ultimately real.

06

Yogācāra, Consciousness-Only and the Three Natures

Context + Exact Core

□ parikalpita-svabhāva — imagined nature □ paratantra-svabhāva — dependent nature □ pariniṣpanna-svabhāva — perfected/consummate nature □□ These explain how deluded objectification arises and how it is overcome.

Mechanism / Argument

□ parikalpita-svabhāva — imagined nature □ paratantra-svabhāva — dependent nature □ pariniṣpanna-svabhāva — perfected/consummate nature □□ These explain how deluded objectification arises and how it is overcome.

Consequence / Contrast

□ Dream argument: dream-objects are vividly experienced despite lacking corresponding external objects; therefore experienced objecthood does not prove external independent matter. □ Atom critique: if atoms are partless, they cannot combine spatially; if they have parts, they are not ultimate atoms.

UPSC Trap / Answer Use

Do not miss this limiting distinction: □ Yogācāra advances vijñāptimātra or consciousness-only. □ What appears as external object is inseparable...

Answer Line: □ Yogācāra advances vijñāptimātra or consciousness-only. □ What appears as external object is inseparable from modes of consciousness.

07

Mādhyamaka, Emptiness, Two Truths and Catuṣkoṭi

Context + Exact Core

□ Associated especially with Nāgārjuna. □ The central thesis is śūnyatā (emptiness): absence of svabhāva (intrinsic nature / own-being), not sheer nothingness. □ In substance, Nāgārjuna identifies dependent origination and emptiness: what is dependently arisen is empty of independent essence.

Mechanism / Argument

□ Early / Nīkāya use: the avyākṛta / avyākṛta questions are often framed through four alternatives, and all four are set aside because they do not conduce to liberation and rest on misleading presuppositions. □ Mādhyamaka use: Nāgārjuna negates all four alternatives when they are applied to things imagined as possessing svabhāva. □□ Thus the early use is primarily therapeutic and soteriological; the Mādhyamaka use is also logical-ontological, because it exposes the incoherence of intrinsic nature.

Consequence / Contrast

□ To say things are empty is to say they lack svabhāva. □ It is not to say they are absent in every sense. □ Since conventional truth remains operative, compassion, karma and the path are not denied. □□ Emptiness undercuts metaphysical grasping, not dependent functioning.

UPSC Trap / Answer Use

□ Associated especially with Nāgārjuna. □ The central thesis is śūnyatā (emptiness): absence of svabhāva (intrinsic nature / own-being), not sheer nothingness. □ In substance, Nāgārjuna identifies dependent origination and emptiness: what is dependently arisen is empty of independent essence.

Answer Line: □ Conventional truth is not mere falsehood; it is the domain within which practical life and Buddhist discipline function. □ Ultimate truth is insight into the emptiness of all reified positions. □ Nāgārjuna warns that emptiness wrongly grasped destroys the dull-witted, like a snake wrongly seized. □□ The two-truths doctrine keeps catuṣkoṭi from collapsing into nihilism: conventional functioning is preserved, ultimate intrinsic being is denied.

08

Creator-God Critique and Internal School Disputes

Context + Exact Core

The Buddhist critique holds that a permanent and perfect creator cannot intelligibly initiate changing effects, acquire a new will, or remain morally insulated from the suffering attributed to creation.

Mechanism / Argument

No creator is required because conditioned causation performs the explanatory work.

Consequence / Contrast

□□ Buddhist critique is not mere atheistic denial; it is a systematic refusal of explanatory surplus.

UPSC Trap / Answer Use

If conditioned arising explains the world-process, God is not needed.

Answer Line: The Buddhist critique holds that a permanent and perfect creator cannot intelligibly initiate changing effects, acquire a new will, or remain morally insulated from the suffering attributed to creation.

09

Inter-school Debates, Objections and Replies

Context + Exact Core

Mādhyamaka draws the anti-essentialist conclusion that dependently originated things are empty of svabhāva. □ Objection → reply: emptiness seems self-defeating or nihilistic.

Mechanism / Argument

Mādhyamika explicitly resists that reading. □□ Trap 6: saying Triratna is inconsistent with no-self because "nobody remains to practise." Buddhism admits a conventional person. □□ Trap 7: answering karma-under-momentariness by smuggling in a hidden soul.

Consequence / Contrast

□□ Exam payoff: for "Schools of Buddhism", do not list four schools mechanically.

UPSC Trap / Answer Use

Buddhism says the real conditioned is momentary, not unreal in every sense. □□ Trap 3: confusing pudgala-nairātmya with dharma-nairātmya. □□ Trap 4: writing that all Buddhist schools say the same thing about the external world.

Answer Line: Nāgārjuna's reply is that emptiness itself is dependent designation and preserves conventional causation rather than abolishing it. <-1- restored-2018-2020-doctrine: end.

10

Dignāga-Dharmakīrti Epistemology and Apoha

Context + Exact Core

□ Apoha (exclusion) says a general term does not denote a real universal (jāti) inhering in particulars. □ A word functions through anya-apoha (exclusion of the other): "cow" means "not-non-cow".

Mechanism / Argument

□ Apoha (exclusion) says a general term does not denote a real universal (jāti) inhering in particulars. □ A word functions through anya-apoha (exclusion of the other): "cow" means "not-non-cow".

Consequence / Contrast

□ Similarity is grounded not in a shared universal but in a shared causal capacity. □ Many distinct particulars produce the same effect: the same conceptual judgment and the same successful practical activity. □ Apoha is a conceptual construct erected upon that causal convergence, not upon a prior grasp of a real universal. □□ The circularity objection retains residual force; many critics hold that the Buddhist reply does not fully explain positive determination.

UPSC Trap / Answer Use

□ On a momentary and non-substantialist ontology, there is no enduring agent-instrument-result triad. □ The analysis into karaṇa (instrument) and phala (result) is a conceptual overlay on one momentary cognitive event. □□ This shows that Buddhist epistemology is internally driven by anātman and kṣaṇikavāda, not by free-standing formal logic.

Answer Line: □□ Why this matters for UPSC: Buddhist epistemology is not an isolated logic chapter.

11

Undeclared Questions, Liberation and Exam Verdict

Context + Exact Core

□ Questions are na arthasamhita (not conducive to the goal / not connected with welfare and liberation). □ The arrow parable in the Cūḷamalūkyā teaching compares the metaphysical questioner to a man shot with a poisoned arrow who refuses treatment until he learns the archer's caste, name, bow-type and arrow-fletching; he dies before treatment. □ The questions rest on a false presupposition: they assume a substantial self or substantial world about which the alternatives can be predicated. □□ The structure resembles the loaded question "Have you stopped beating your wife?"; any direct answer concedes the presupposition. □ Conditioned cognition cannot settle what is framed beyond the conditions of meaningful experience and liberation-oriented practice.

Mechanism / Argument

Avyākāta: questions left undeclared because they do not conduce to liberation.

Consequence / Contrast

□ Avyākāta / avyākṛta (undeclared / unanswered) questions are questions the Buddha declines to answer in the expected metaphysical format. □ They include whether the world is eternal or not eternal, finite or infinite; whether the jīva (life-principle / self) is the same as or different from the body; and whether the Tathāgata exists after death, does not exist, both, or neither.

UPSC Trap / Answer Use

□ The questions are na arthasamhita (not conducive to the goal / not connected with welfare and liberation). □ The arrow parable in the Cūḷamalūkyā teaching compares the metaphysical questioner to a man shot with a poisoned arrow who refuses treatment until he learns the archer's caste, name, bow-type and arrow-fletching; he dies before treatment. □ The questions rest on a false presupposition: they assume a substantial self or substantial world about which the alternatives can be predicated. □□ The structure resembles the loaded question "Have you stopped beating your wife?"; any direct answer concedes the presupposition. □ Conditioned cognition cannot settle what is framed beyond the conditions of meaningful experience and liberation-oriented practice.

Answer Line: Final verdict: Buddhist philosophy replaces substantial identity with dependent continuity, but its success depends on explaining how causal efficacy, knowledge and liberation remain coherent without a permanent self or intrinsic essence.